

DECISIVE MOMENT October 12, 1492 2 a.m.

Columbus lands in the Caribbean

The arrival of a small, Spanish-sponsored fleet on the Caribbean island of San Salvador was to have dramatic effects on both sides of the Atlantic Ocean. European explorers would be galvanized by the discovery of what eventually proved to be two whole new continents, while the native populations were about to enter a period of prolonged suffering and repression.

Christopher Columbus was born in Genoa around 1451, going to sea at an early age. For eight years he sought sponsors for a plan to sail west from Europe to eastern Asia and the island kingdom of Cipangu (Japan). By finding a direct sea route to Asia, he hoped to open the wealth of the region for European trade. He finally won backing from Isabella of Castille (see pp. 226–27) in 1491.

Columbus set off from the Spanish port of Palos on August 3, 1492. His fleet consisted of a three-masted cargo ship, the *Santa Maria*, carrying 40 men, the smaller *Pinta*, with 26 men, and the four-masted *Niña*, with 24 aboard. The fleet dropped anchor in the Canary Islands, southwest of Spain, for repairs, but on September 6 it finally resumed its journey across the Atlantic.

On the evening of October 11, 1492, Columbus, aboard the *Santa Maria*, thought he saw “a light to the west. It looked like a little wax candle bobbing up and down.” Two hours after midnight, Rodrigo de Triana,

lookout on the *Pinta*, sighted land. Columbus had crossed the Atlantic.

He claimed the island he had found for Spain, naming it San Salvador, and traded with the Arawak natives (calling them “Indians,” in the belief that he was off the coast of Asia). The island’s true location is unclear—for years, it was assumed to be present-day San Salvador in the Bahamas, but in 1986 a team from the US National Geographical Society judged it must have been Samana Cay, 78 miles (125 km) southeast, and a later study concluded it was probably Grand Turk, 200 miles (320 km) farther southeast.

On October 14, Columbus set off in search of gold. He explored three small islands before sailing to Cuba, and then to Hispaniola (Dominican Republic and Haiti), where he established the first European transatlantic settlement since the Vikings (see pp. 202–203), 500 years earlier. On January 16, 1493, he set off back to Spain, convinced that he had sailed to Asia and back.

Columbus makes landfall

Columbus was captivated by the island he named San Salvador (meaning “Saint Savior”). “Everything is green and the vegetation is like that in Andalusia in April.” He did not, however, discover the gold he sought, nor did he realize that this was not an outlying island of Asia, but part of a new continent—the Americas.

“...in honor of **God** who guided us and **saved us from many perils.**”

COLUMBUS'S WORDS AFTER CLAIMING SAN SALVADOR FOR SPAIN, OCTOBER 12, 1492

